

# Demographic Change, Social Distance, and Policy Preferences: Empirical Evidence from India\*

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## Abstract

Though political scientists generally understand how demographic changes affect relations between the majority and the minority, less is known about how they affect relations within the majority. I study this question using a survey experiment in India ( $N = 1208$ ), where between 1950 and 2020, the Muslim population has grown by over 170 million. Results show that priming respondents with population shifts exacerbates social distance between upper and lower-caste Hindus. However, they also lead both subgroups to prioritize “collective” policies that benefit Hindus as a whole over “divisive” policies that redress caste disparities. Together, these findings suggest that outgroup threats can induce collective mobilization without actually improving social cohesion, helping explain when and why disadvantaged (sub)groups act against their own interests.

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# Introduction

Demographic change has upended politics around the globe. Whether through rising immigration or diverging birthrates, both developed countries like Australia and France and developing countries like India and Nigeria have become increasingly diverse in the past few decades. In response to these trends, social scientists have produced a voluminous literature investigating how population shifts affect relations between the majority and the minority (Abascal 2020; Craig and Richeson 2014a; Craig and Richeson 2014b; Outten, Schmitt, Miller, and Garcia 2012). In this article, I study how they affect relations within the majority itself.

“Majorities,” across a variety of contexts, are internally differentiated, socially stratified, and politically fragmented. Importantly, some subgroups are frequently positioned hierarchically above others. In Pakistan, for example, where Muslims form the dominant group, Shias experience significant discrimination from Sunnis (Nellis and Siddiqui 2018). In the United Kingdom, the Scottish comprise part of the native majority but perceive themselves as undermined by the English (Sindic and Reicher 2009). Even Israel, a country usually assumed to be divided into majority Jews and minority Arabs, possesses a stark social cleavage between Ashkenazi and Mizrahi Jews (Elia-Shalev 2022).

These hierarchies often lead different subgroups of the majority to hold conflicting positions on issues from redistribution to even foreign policy,<sup>1</sup> with disadvantaged sections typically favoring policies that challenge the status quo (Chhibber and Verma 2018<sup>2</sup>; Evans and Duffy 1997<sup>3</sup>). While previous studies do show that population shifts induce majorities to identify with the ingroup and mobilize toward “policies that protect the group” (Jardina 2019; Craig and Richeson 2014a; Craig and Richeson 2014b), we remain uncertain how they affect the salience of these hierarchies or the policy preferences they give rise to.

In this study, I report the results of a pre-registered online survey experiment in India, where between 1950 and 2020, the Muslim population has grown by over 170 million. Although Hindus in India

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<sup>1</sup>For example, Pakistani Shias notably lobby for closer relations with Iran, in contrast with Pakistani Sunnis who prefer closer ties with Saudi Arabia (Ahmed and Akbarzadeh 2018).

<sup>2</sup>Chhibber and Verma (2018) show that lower-caste Hindus are more supportive of affirmative action and redistributive policies than upper-caste Hindus.

<sup>3</sup>Evans and Duffy (1997) show that lower-class Protestants in Northern Ireland were more supportive of redistributive policies and parties than upper-class Protestants.

make up a simple majority, forming approximately 79% of the population (“Religious Composition of India” 2021), they remain deeply internally divided along the lines of caste. In my experiment, 1121 Hindu participants from North India either read a neutral passage or a treatment passage priming population shifts before answering questions on group identification, social distance, and policy preferences.

To preview my results, I find that exposure to treatment catalyzes the superordinate Hindu identity. Contrary to expectations, this exacerbates social distance between upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus. However, it still motivates them to consolidate politically behind policies designed to improve the ingroup’s collective position over Indian Muslims. By increasing support for these “pro-Hindu policies,” I show that priming Hindus to think about increasing diversity undermines support from both upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus for “pro-caste policies” designed to redistribute within the group. Put together, these results suggest that outgroup threats can motivate groups to consolidate politically despite the persistence or even intensification of internal cleavages. This political consolidation, however, will come at the expense of policies that redress intragroup disparities.

This study makes three major contributions. First, it adds to a rich literature in the social sciences investigating the effects of minority group size (Perez et al., 2023; Craig and Richeson 2014a; Craig and Richeson 2014b; Allport, Clark, and Pettigrew 1954). To date, most research has focused on how population shifts affect relations between groups, investigating, for example, the effects of immigration on native backlash (Choi, Poertner, & Sambanis 2021) or the effects of Hispanic immigration on Black-White relations in the United States (Fouka and Tabellini 2021). This study breaks new ground, establishing empirically that priming group members to think about outgroup population changes can affect relations within the ingroup as well.

Second, it leverages a novel design that asks respondents to choose explicitly between policies that benefit the superordinate group collectively and policies that benefit one or more subgroup(s) at the expense of others. In doing so, it shows that superordinate identities can undermine mobilization for social change. My findings suggest that in other contexts where political competition already places superordinate and subordinate goals in contention, identifying with the common ingroup can induce group members to prefer improvements to the superordinate group’s collective position over intragroup social justice. This framework helps explain when and why disadvantaged (sub)groups, both in India

and elsewhere in the world, act against their own interests.

Third, this study improves our understanding of Indian politics specifically. Prior research largely deals with caste cleavages or religious cleavages independently, with nary a reference to the other. This differs strongly from understandings of politics on the ground, where a common refrain is that the religious right plays the “communal” Hindu-Muslim card to avoid talking about caste (Purohit 2023; Dwivedi, Mohan, and Reghu 2020). I provide causal evidence for this claim at the individual level. In doing so, I advance the study of political and social psychology outside the WEIRD<sup>4</sup> contexts in which it is usually studied. In this way, I hope that this project helps cast light on the dark corners of the map, which were hitherto demarcated only by “here be dragons.”

## Theory and Hypotheses

Around the world, nearly every country includes a majority and minority group(s) (Staerklé, Sidanius, Green, and Molina 2010; Horowitz 2000). However, political competition and social interaction, more broadly are usually more complex than this simple binary suggests. Majorities typically feature differentiated internal categories that allocate members into different subordinate groups (Moss 2016; Doane 1997). These subordinate identities frequently form the basis for intragroup conflict and antagonism.

Social identity theory (SIT) (Huddy 2001; Tajfel, Turner, Austin, and Worchel 1979), although originally developed to explain intergroup behavior, offers insights into these intragroup dynamics (Dovidio, Saguy, and Shnabel 2009). Under SIT, individuals are fundamentally motivated by the desire to maintain a positive self-image (Malik 2023). One’s self-concept is at least partly determined by the social groups one belongs to, so individuals can achieve a positive self-evaluation by ensuring that their ingroup compares favorably to other outgroup(s) (Perez 2015). This process generally induces ingroup favoritism (Hogg and Turner 1987), and frequently, outgroup derogation as well (Branscombe, Ellemers, Spears, and Doosje 1999).

Just as individuals are driven to elevate the ingroup in comparison to outgroups, they are motivated to elevate their subgroup over other subgroups within the superordinate category (Stone and

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<sup>4</sup>Western, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic (Henrich, Heine, and Norenzayan 2010)

Crisp 2007). This drive for positive distinctiveness typically leads subordinate groups to express ingroup favoritism and outgroup bias at the subgroup level (Charnysh, Lucas, and Singh 2015; Waldzus, Mummendey, Wenzel, and Weber 2003).

Whereas subordinate identities tend to produce intragroup conflict and competition, the Common Ingroup Identity Model (CIIM) (Gaertner and Dovidio 2000) builds on prior implications from the SIT framework to suggest that superordinate identities facilitate cohesion and cooperation (Perez, Vicuna, and Ramos 2023; Levendusky 2018). In its simplest form, the CIIM suggests that superordinate categories, by recategorizing former outgroup members into a common ingroup, lead individuals to extend the benefits of ingroup favoritism to members of the shared broader category, even when they previously constituted members of different and distinct subgroups (Stone and Crisp 2007).

The simple presence of a superordinate category, however, is often not enough to modulate behavior toward cooperation and cohesion. Self-categorization Theory (SCT) (Turner, Hogg, Oakes, Reicher, and Wetherell, 1987; Turner 1985) suggests that the influence of an identity on behavior is dependent on the degree to which individuals internalize that identity in question. Put simply, identities *matter* to the extent that individuals categorize themselves as a member of that group. Every individual holds numerous identities with which they can possibly identify (Hickel, Alamillo, Oskoi, and Collingwood 2020; Posner 2019). SCT predicts that, once these multiple self-categorizations have been acquired, their influence is ultimately determined by the particular context in which these identities are evaluated (Barrett, Wilson, and Lyons 1999).

Group threat, at least partially, determines context, and therefore, the acquisition and activation of group identities (Jardina 2019). Threats from the outgroup, whether real or perceived, tend to alter the salience of group boundaries (Sambanis and Lee 2023), with seminal works across a variety of contexts showing that they increase ingroup identification, whether the ingroup so defined is racial (Dawson 1995), ethnic (Malik 2023) or sexual (Spoor and Schmitt 2011).

## Demographic Change and Group Identification

In contexts with rising diversity, this framework helps explain group behavior. Prior theorizing across multiple social scientific disciplines tells us that group size is often perceived as a heuristic for group advantage or dominance (Craig and Richeson 2014; Outten, Schmitt, Miller, and Garcia 2012). Demographic change, then, heralds a threat to the status of the dominant group, promising increased competition around both “realistic” material resources like political power and economic opportunities (Abascal 2020; Allport, Clark, and Pettigrew, 1954) and “symbolic” resources like status and belongingness (Brown, Rucker, and Richeson 2021; Danbold and Huo 2015).

A burgeoning literature<sup>5</sup> shows that exposure to large numbers of racial and ethnic minorities tends to induce threat perceptions, and consequently, the salience of the dominant ingroup’s identity (Perez et al., 2023; Abascal 2020; Jardina 2019; Craig and Richeson 2014a; Craig and Richeson 2014b). Importantly, these demographic threats stemming from increases in the outgroup population constitute a shared threat to the common superordinate ingroup. Since this threat is directed towards the common identity and not individually and distinctly towards different subgroups, my first hypothesis is as follows:

**Hypothesis 1.** *Demographic change, a superordinate threat, induces identification with the superordinate group.*

Building on insights from the CIIM, I argue that the recognition of such shared superordinate threats should produce a process of recategorization by which previously distinct subgroups now perceive themselves predominantly as members of the same common ingroup. This cognitive realignment should prompt individuals to downplay characteristics associated with their conflicting subgroup affiliations in favor of the unifying superordinate identity instead (Sambanis and Lee 2023; Gaertner and Dovidio, 2000). My second hypothesis, therefore, is as follows:

**Hypothesis 2.** *Demographic change, a superordinate threat, reduces affiliation with subordinate groups.*

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<sup>5</sup>Albeit predominantly from Western contexts.

## Demographic Change and Social Distance

The categorization of individuals into ingroups, the “like mes”, and outgroups, the “unlike mes” (Tajfel, Turner, Austin, and Worchell 1979) affects not only identification with different groups but social relations. Individuals tend to evaluate fellow group members positively while applying negative stereotypes to members of the outgroup (Alexander, Brewer, and Hermann 1999; Hagendoorn 1993). A bevy of studies show that ingroup members tend to prefer to marry (Wang 2020) and even reside near (Frey 1979) other ingroup members, not only across identities like religion or ethnicity for which the content of the identity might shape such concerns, but even for identities like partisanship.

If a shared superordinate threat induces ingroup members to recategorize outgroup members as part of the common ingroup, identify more with that common ingroup, and less with their prior subgroups, exposure to the common external threat should reduce the bias between ingroup and outgroup members within the majority. In line with a large literature suggesting that the activation of common identities induces positive attitudes towards and willingness to engage with members of former outgroups (Craig, DeHart, Richeson, & Fiederowicz, 2012; Cunningham, 2005), my third hypothesis is as follows:

**Hypothesis 3.** *Demographic change, a superordinate threat, reduces social distance between different subordinate groups.*

## Demographic Change and Policy Positions

Political scientists have produced numerous studies investigating the role groups play in motivating political behavior (Jardina 2019; Huddy 2013; Campbell, Converse, Miller, and Stokes 1960). Their findings are almost unanimous: group membership, by itself, cannot strongly motivate political attitudes or policy preferences (see McClain, Johnson Carew, Walton, and Watts 2009). For groups to be politically relevant, they require group consciousness. Group members must not only experience a sense of belonging to the group but also a conscious commitment to the goals and betterment of the group as well (Stokes 2003; Miller, Gurin, Gurin, and Malanchuk 1981). In contexts where subordinate groups are internally heterogeneous, group consciousness might be difficult to attain (Conway and Wong 2004; DeSipio 1996).

External threats politicize group identity (Perez et al., 2023; Craig and Richeson 2014b), in that they motivate members toward collective action (Dawson 1994). The basic logic is simple: recognition of a shared superordinate threat to the status and interests of one's subgroup, as well as other subgroups as well, can reduce group differentiation and induce feelings of shared status. Together, this can mobilize group members towards superordinate goals, such as redressing the original threat (Kim, 2023; Chin, Luna, Huo, Perez, 2022; Zepeda-Millan, 2017). This leads me to Hypothesis 4 as follows:

**Hypothesis 4.** *Demographic change, a superordinate threat, induces support for collective policies that benefit the whole superordinate group.*

Different subgroups of the majority frequently hold divergent interests, with disadvantaged sections often championing redistributive policies like welfare and affirmative action that are opposed by more advantaged sections. While external threats induce identification with the common ingroup, promoting group consciousness, they attenuate attachments to the original subgroup, undermining subgroup consciousness. This, I contend, erodes commitments to subgroup-specific goals, demobilizing subgroup mobilization. Consequently, the following hypothesis contends that superordinate threats weaken support for “divisive” policies like welfare and affirmative action when they are opposed by advantaged sections of the common ingroup.

**Hypothesis 5.** *Demographic change, a superordinate threat, reduces support for divisive policies that either only benefit some subgroups or benefit some subgroups at the expense of others.*

Prior applications of the CIIM have produced contradictory findings regarding the mobilizing and demobilizing role of common identities. One strand of the literature contends that the process of re-categorization boosts support for policies that do not directly implicate one's narrower ingroup, inducing support for inclusive policies that benefit disadvantaged sections of the common ingroup (Perez, Vicuna, and Ramos 2023; Perez 2021; Dovidio, Gartner, and Kafati 2000). Another contends that common identities can demobilize demands for social change (Górska and Bilewicz, 2015; Ufkes, Dovidio, and Tel 2015). Given the contrary expectations for Hypothesis 5, I put forward my final *weaker* hypothesis: if external threats do not undermine support for subgroup policies absolutely, they will undermine them relatively, altering policy *choice*.



**Hypothesis 6.** *Demographic change, a superordinate threat, motivates group members to prioritize collective policies over divisive policies.*

## **The Context: Caste, Community, and Politics in India**

Hindus constitute the dominant majority in India, making up some 80% of the country's population ("Religious Composition of India" 2021). Yet, Hindu as an identity cannot but be a superordinate one. Every Hindu holds a subordinate caste affiliation associated with a hereditary endogamous ethnic group (Munshi 2019). The caste system, a hierarchical system of social stratification, ranks these castes by order of ritual purity (Agte and Bernhardt 2023). The basis of this caste system emanates from Hindu texts, which classify the community into four varnas: the Brahmins, responsible for education and rituals; the Kshatriyas, associated with warfare and ruling; the Vaishyas, responsible for mercantile pursuits; and the Shudras, associated with tilling the soil and artisanal crafts. Outside this varna system are the Scheduled Castes (SCs) or "untouchables" and the Scheduled Tribes (STs) or indigenous peoples (Flood 1996).

These caste distinctions profoundly shape contemporary social relations. Traditionally, lower-caste Hindus, particularly the untouchables, were marginalized to the outskirts of villages (Srinivas 1955). This dynamic of exclusion persists in modern times, with contemporary Indian cities remaining highly segregated (Singh, Vithayathil and Pradhan 2019). While the caste norms surrounding inter-dining have certainly attenuated, newspapers still report incidents of schools firing staff on discovering their caste identities (Rajput 2021). Finally, caste subgroups continue to be highly endogamous, with the vast majority of Hindus still marrying within their caste (Banerjee, Duflo, Ghatak, and Lafortune 2013). In fact, Pew (2021) data reports that more than 60% of Indians say that it is very important to stop *others* from marrying across caste lines.

For these reasons, it is not surprising that Caste identities have long informed Indian political behavior and policy preferences. Many Indians vote along caste lines (Banerjee and Pande 2007) for "caste parties" that promise to secure power and represent the interests of the caste group that constitutes their natural constituency (Weiner 2001). Some scholars contend that these parties are non-ideological,

merely serving as vehicles for clientelism and the enrichment of political elites (Chandra 2007). However, nearly every caste party supports policies designed to tackle caste-based disparities (Thachil and Teitelbaum 2015).

In this article, I focus on two categories of these policies. The first deals with India's affirmative action system that reserves seats in educational institutions, the bureaucracy, and the legislatures for the lower-castes (Osborne 2001). These policies were initially introduced by India's constituent assembly in the 1950s, and were (i) limited to the Scheduled Castes and (ii) only intended to function for ten years. Although successive governments have maintained these policies and even extended them to new beneficiaries (the OBCs) (Suryanarayan 2019), elements of the Hindu right have consistently attacked these policies, leading to fears of their cancellation or dilution (Jaffrelot 2021).

Importantly, even though these policies provide lower-caste Hindus with a seat at the table, it does not mean they are treated equally or with any respect at all, at the table. Lower-caste Hindus who come to top universities through affirmative action are regularly treated poorly by their peers, professors, and even university staff (Pathania and Tierney 2018). Frequently, this psychological pressure has proved so intractable, that students at these top universities ended up committing suicide (Pathania and Tierney 2018; Kumar 2016).

The second deals with government spending and redistribution. Caste-parties and India's official opposition party, the Indian National Congress, have campaigned for the restitution of encroached Mahhar and Panchami land (land reserved for Dalit farmers) to its intended beneficiaries (Indian National Congress 2019). Similarly, parties regularly issue electoral promises to guarantee basic amenities like water and electricity to lower-caste members who suffer from inadequate access on account of residential segregation and local underprovision (Chadha 2022).

These policy platforms reflect the positions many lower-caste Hindus report in surveys of their political attitudes and preferences. Although Indian politics has long been castigated as non-ideological, evidence indicates that lower-caste Hindus tend to support a stronger role of the state and a "politics of representation" that provides them with descriptive representation and access to the halls of power (Chhibber and Verma 2018).

While Hindus and their subcategories constitute some 80% of India's population, Muslims make

up another 14.2% (“Religious Composition of India” 2021). These numbers represent a small but significant change to India’s demographic profile. After the partition of British India and the formation of Pakistan, India numbered 35 million Muslims among its citizens, constituting just under 10% of the population (Census of India, 1951). Since then, both India’s Hindu and Muslim populations have grown rapidly, with diverging birth rates and death rates producing a 4% increase in the Muslim population share (Bhagat 2015).

Compared to countries like the United States, where the dominant majority, Whites, have reduced from nearly 90% of the population to just over 70% of the population (U.S. Census Bureau 2020), population shifts in India must seem small indeed. They are. However, the fear of demographic change has shaped Hindu politics for over a century. In 1909, Upendro Nath Mukherjee published the book *“Hindus: A Dying Race,”* shaping Hindu thinking around demographics for multiple generations (Datta 1993). This work inspired later ones, with the Hindu Mahasabha publishing in 1979 another work, *“They Count Their Gains — We Calculate Our Losses,”* the “they” in question, of course, being Muslims (Prakash 1979).

Contemporary Indian political discourse regularly makes reference to these anxieties. For example, then Chief Minister Narendra Modi famously stated after the 2002 ethnic pogroms in his state, *“Hum do, hamare do, woh paanch, unke pachees”* (we are two, our two, they are five, their twenty-five) (Strohl, 2019). Other members of his party, the *Bharatiya Janata Party* (BJP), have offered similar statements. Another party veteran, Subramaniam Swamy, stated *“Hindus are facing a terrible pincer; Islamic fast population growth and illegal migration, in conjunction with Christian money-induced conversion activities”* (Jaffrelot 2021). Most strikingly, these are not just throwaway comments by wayward leaders. The BJP links articles on its website detailing these demographic threats, accusing other parties of ignoring their consequences for India’s national security (Bharatiya Janata Party, n.d.).

One way Hindu identity manifests itself politically is through support for policies that target India’s religious minorities. For one example, in 2019, the BJP introduced two bills, the National Register of Citizens and the Citizenship Amendment Act. The first sought to register all citizens in India, enabling the identification of those who have immigrated illegally. The second provided a pathway to citizenship for Hindus, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Christians, and Parsis illegal immigrants, but not Muslim ones (Roy

2022). Together, these policies could lead numerous poorer Muslims who lack documentation to lose citizenship (see, for example, Gani 2019).

Another example are the ordinances passed in Uttar Pradesh and other north Indian states that effectively ban interfaith marriages (Ahmed 2021). These policies were presented as simply attempts to mitigate the threat of *Love Jihad*, an alleged scheme by which Muslim men seek to lure non-Muslim women into marriage and then force them to convert, give birth to many children, and educate them according to the precepts of Islam (Malji and Raza 2021). Functionally, they make it impossible to prove one's marriage was not coerced and allow any relative to place a halt on an interfaith marriage before or even after it is conducted. Indeed, the Hindu right regularly refers to even consensual marriages between Hindu women and Muslim men as Love Jihad (Strohl 2019), suggesting that these policies were designed to serve such a purpose.

One final expression of Hindu dominance regularly leveraged by the BJP is the *bulldozer* (Sahu 2022). Communal violence regularly breaks out across North India (Wilkinson 2006; Varshney 2003). The bulldozer forms one stick in the arsenal of BJP governments to prevent riots. Instead of waiting for courts to adjudicate, the government sends in bulldozers immediately to tear down the houses, whether illegally constructed or not, of rioters and looters. Already illegal, since it violates the rule of law, its usage is also partial. BJP governments only flag Muslim houses for demolition, and never those of Hindu participants. This naked exercise of power has spread beyond Uttar Pradesh to other states as well.

It is important to note that I am in no way contending that these are the only policies or actions the BJP promulgates. Indeed, numerous studies document that the BJP's expansion from an upper-caste party to a broader Hindu party that secures the support of many lower-caste Hindus as well depended on the party embracing private service provision (Thachil 2014) and some forms of public redistribution (Jaffrelot 2021). In choosing these policies, I aim to form a hard test for my hypotheses, by asking respondents to choose between caste-based material policies that could reflect genuine improvements to the material standard of some Hindus, and culture war symbolic issues, that might boost positive distinctiveness but mean little material gain.

## Research Design

To test my hypotheses, I designed and administered an online experiment to 1121 Indian Hindus in December 2023. I randomly assigned participants to either read a “neutral” article or a “treatment” article communicating India’s changing religious demographics. Empirically, I made use of a classic mediation model, where the indirect effects of treatment on outcomes are transmitted through a mediating variable that is observed but not manipulated (Perez, Vicuña, & Ramos, 2023; Hayes, 2021). This allows me to establish a causal chain linking treatment to outcomes through the mediator. However, I cannot make causal claims directly linking the mediator to its downstream effects on outcomes.

## Sample

I recruited participants in partnership with Qualtrics, an online survey platform that aggregates respondents previously enrolled by other firms (Boas, Christenson, & Glick, 2020). I screened out non-Hindu respondents and allowed eligible participants to complete the survey in either English or Hindi. Although responses were not yielded probabilistically, Qualtrics samples are highly heterogeneous and more representative than the convenience samples typically used in political psychological work in the global south. The median respondent was 29 years old, with a college education and an annual household income between Rs 3,00,000 and Rs 10,00,000. 32.43% of respondents were women, 46.31% resided outside Tier-1 cities, and 66.55% belonged to the general category, while 33.45% were lower-caste.

Similar to other online samples recruited in India through MTurk, Facebook, or Lucid (see Haas & Lindstam, 2023; Guess et al., 2020), my sample is more urban, wealthier, and more educated than the general public. My results, therefore, pertain better to Indian internet users, particularly from larger cities, than to broader Indian society. Nevertheless, prior results from convenience samples often replicate in higher quality probabilistic samples (Coppock, 2019). Furthermore, internet connectivity in India has improved by leaps and bounds, making online samples more representative of the general public<sup>6</sup>.

Participants come from four states: *Uttar Pradesh, Delhi, Maharashtra, and Gujarat*. Together, these states elect 161/543 seats to India’s lower house of parliament. In limiting my sample to these

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<sup>6</sup>NES data, for example, suggests that by 2019, 45.2% of Indians had internet access on their mobile phones and that WhatsApp and Facebook were used by nearly 31.4% and 27.8% of Indians, respectively (Lokniti, 2019).

specific states, I try to strike a good balance between study generalizability and holding constant the sociopolitical background that informs participant responses. Included in this sample is Uttar Pradesh, India's most populous state, two Tier-1 cities (Delhi and Mumbai), and two states outside India's Hindi heartlands (Maharashtra and Gujarat). Despite these differences, each of these states has a sizable Muslim minority, a stratified caste hierarchy, and a political system where both caste and religion help determine political attitudes and behaviors.

## **Survey Design and Experiment Treatment**

After providing informed consent, respondents began the survey by answering a battery of demographic questions, including age, gender, education, income, and urban/rural residence. Importantly, I asked respondents to identify which caste group and which *jati* they belonged to. Embedded in this survey is the actual experiment, which randomly assigned participants to either the control group, which exposed participants to a neutral article on the rising Asiatic lion population, or the treatment group, which exposed participants to an article on the rising Muslim population share.

In designing the treatment article, I invoked three “symbols” or enduring emotion-laden predispositions (Sears, 2001; Sears, 1993) that underlie demographic fears in India. First, the right-wing regularly makes references to cities or states where Hindus now constitute a minority; hence, I allude to Kashmir, old Hyderabad, and Malappuram in the treatment passage. Second, narratives around Muslim fecundity have long shaped these demographic anxieties, so I include references to National Family Health Survey (NFHS) data suggesting that Muslim families tend to be larger than Hindu families. Finally, I state explicitly that demographic changes might constitute not just a mechanical change in numbers but a “power threat” (Perez et al., 2023) that makes Muslim candidates more likely to win elections and secure a more unified and robust voice in the halls of power.

After reading the article, all participants completed a manipulation check to ensure that they were, in fact, treated. Respondents were asked whether the given passage said that the lion / Muslim population was increasing or decreasing. Across both conditions, a total of 127 participants answered incorrectly, failing the manipulation check. This constituted about 11.33% of the sample. Per my pre-registration, I

excluded such respondents from my analyses.

Following my manipulation check, respondents answered questions gauging group identification, perceived social distance, policy support, and policy preferences. To measure group identification, I asked respondents, “How important is being Hindu to your identity?” on a 4-point scale (4 = very important, 3 = somewhat important, 2 = a little important, 1 = not at all important). I then asked, measured on the same scale, “How important is being (Respondent’s Jati) to your identity?”

For my main measure of social distance, I asked respondents on a 3-point scale running from *a lot* to *not at all* the following three (3) questions: (1) If a family from a different caste with about the same income and education as you moved next door, how strongly would you object? (2) If a member of your family wanted to bring a friend from a different caste home for dinner, how strongly would you object? (3) If your son or daughter were to marry someone from a different caste, how strongly would you object? I also combined responses to these three questions together additively into a 9-point scale. As an alternative measure that captures the political consequences of social distance more explicitly, I asked respondents to agree/disagree on a 5-point scale running from *Strongly agree* to *Strongly disagree* with the following statement: Instead of fighting, upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus should work together to improve their common position.

For policy support, I first measured attitudes towards existing caste-based affirmative action policies. I asked respondents to agree/disagree on a 5-point scale from *Strongly agree* to *Strongly disagree* with the following two (2) statements: (1) I support Scheduled Caste/Scheduled Tribe reservations and (2) I support Other Backward Classes reservations. Next, I measured attitudes towards future policies I sourced from party manifestos. Measured on a 4-point scale running from *very important* to *not at all important*, I asked respondents how important it was to achieve the following aims within the next ten years: (1) Complete the (NRC/CAA) National Registrar of Citizens / Citizenship Amendment Act process and throw out illegal immigrants, (2) Redistribute village land to SC/ST farmers, (3) Stop Love Jihad, (4) Guarantee basic amenities like electricity and water for SC/STs). I report results for each policy separately and for additive indices combining the “pro-Hindu” policies and “pro-caste policies” together.

To quantify policy preferences, I pit religious and caste concerns directly in opposition, asking

respondents to pick which of the above four (4) future policies they considered the most important. I operationalized this measure by testing whether respondents picked one of the pro-Hindu policies (1, 3) or one of the pro-caste policies (2, 4). Next, I measured how respondents chose between the most popular pro-Hindu policy and the most popular pro-caste policy. Finally, I asked respondents, “If you had the opportunity to sign on to one of two letters to parliament, which letter would you rather sign?” giving respondents a choice between two letters, one urging the government to pass policies to tackle rioters and looters (read Muslims) and protect the Hindu community and the other urging the government to pass policies to reduce student suicides (read lower-caste Hindus) in IITs/IIMs.

## Results

I organize results around my stated hypotheses. I start with group identification and then turn to social distance, policy support, and policy preferences. My final sample includes  $N = 994$  Hindus, of which 665 (66.9%) were upper-caste Hindus and 329 (33.1%) were lower-caste Hindus. Before conducting any of my analyses, I tested whether random assignment had successfully balanced covariates across the two experimental conditions. For ten variables measured pre-treatment, Table A1 reports the mean or population share across the control and treatment groups. Without exception, balance tests at a 5% level indicate successful randomization. This reduces the need to control for spurious relationships in the following analyses.

## Identification

I begin by assessing whether priming demographic threats alters group identification. As outcomes, I focus on identifying as Hindu and identifying as a member of one’s *Jati* or caste. Compared with the control group, I find that respondents in the treatment group displayed a 2.3% increase in Hindu identification (s.e.=0.012,  $p=0.059$ ). This result is consistent with H1. It is difficult to identify heterogeneous effects on account of the small number of respondents in each subgroup<sup>7</sup>. That said, results suggest

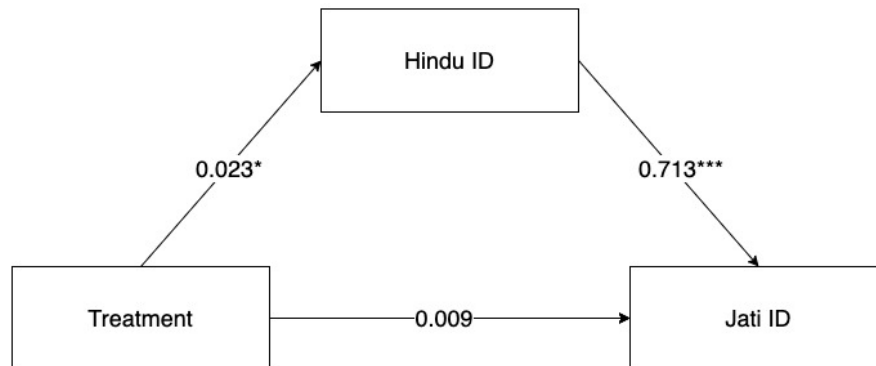
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<sup>7</sup>Estimates from my power analysis recommended approximately  $N = 1000$  to estimate results with 80% power and I pre-registered a sample of 1200 respondents.



comparable effect sizes, with upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus reporting a 2.1% and 2.7% increase in Hindu identification, respectively.

**FIGURE 1. Exposure to Demographic Threat Increases Both Hindu Identification and Caste Identification**



*Note:* This path diagram depicts the indirect effect of Treatment on Caste Identification, mediated through Hindu Identification. Coefficients are taken from the first column in Table 2.

Given that treatment increases Hindu identification, how then does it affect the salience of caste identities? Figure 1 portrays both the relationship between treatment and Hindu identification and the downstream effects of Hindu identification on caste affiliation. Contrary to H2, I find that a unit increase in Hindu identification is associated with a 0.713 (s.e.=0.046,  $p < 0.01$ ) *increase* in subgroup identification. Interacting Hindu identification with caste membership suggests that effects are marginally smaller for lower-caste Hindus (0.65) than upper-caste Hindus (0.753), although this difference is not statistically significant.

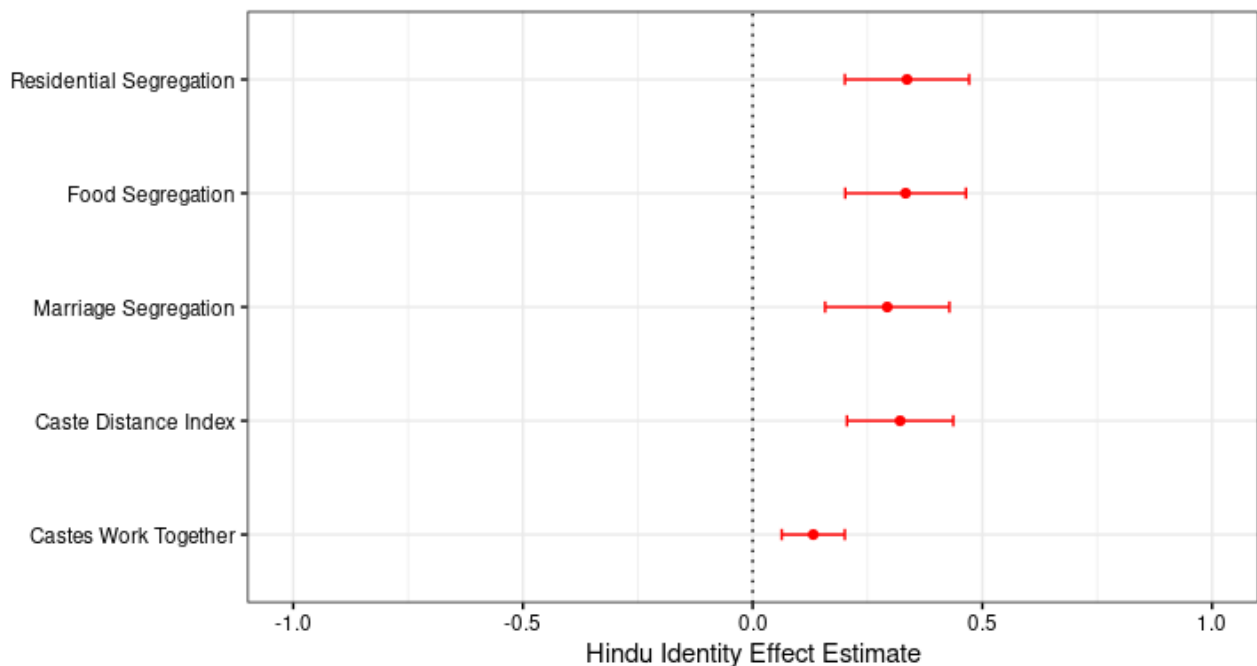
Following Hayes (2021), I compute the ACME (Average Causal Mediation Effect) by multiplying the coefficient of Hindu ID on Treatment (0.023\*) with the coefficient of Jati ID on Hindu ID (0.713\*\*\*). This quantity measures the full pathway from demographic threats to caste identification and allows me to test whether the effect is distinguishable from zero (Perez, Vicuña, & Ramos 2023). The ACME is positive (0.016\*) and reliable at the 7% level or better. Together, these findings suggest that priming Hindus to think about the rising Muslim population share leads them to identify more with their religion

(by 2.3%) but identify more with their caste (by 1.6%) as well.

## Social Distance

Next, I test how priming demographic threats alters intragroup relations between upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus. Figure 2 depicts the downstream associations between Hindu identification and a battery of social distance measures. As outcomes, I consider opposition to residing near, opposition to eating with, and opposition to marrying Hindus of different castes. I also consider support for mobilizing together to achieve shared interests.

**FIGURE 2. Marginal Effects of Hindu Identification on Social Distance**



*Note:* This figure displays marginal effects of Hindu Identification on different measures on Social Distance. Coefficients are based on Table A2 in the appendix. 95% confidence intervals are shown. Outcome variables range from 0-1.

I find that higher Hindu identification is *positively* associated with opposition to residing near (0.336, s.e.=0.069,  $p<0.001$ ), eating with (0.333, s.e.=0.067,  $p<0.01$ ), or marrying (0.293, s.e.=0.069,  $p<0.01$ ) Hindus belonging to other castes. Combining these measures into an additive index reveals that

the relationship between Hindu identification and social distance between upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus is positive, statistically significant, and substantively meaningful (0.321, s.e.=0.059,  $p<0.01$ ). Contrary to H3, this suggests that identifying as Hindu, rather than reducing, increases social distance from Hindus of other castes. As Table A2 indicates, these findings emerge from both upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus, although the increases in social distance appear larger in the former than the latter.

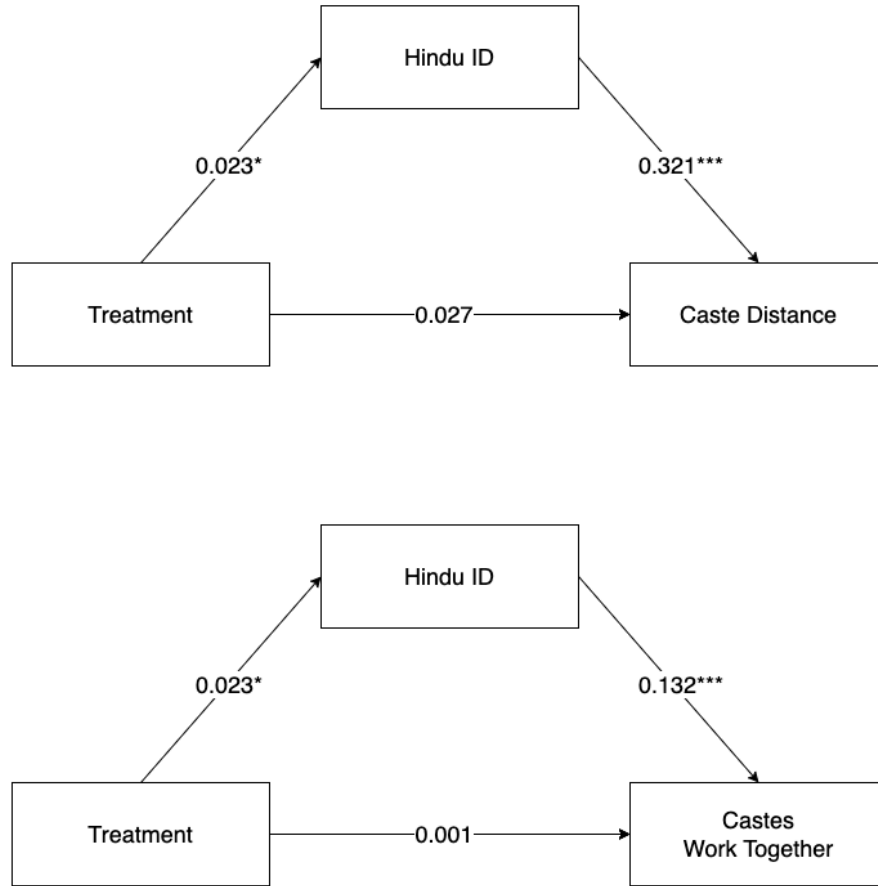
Next, I find that Hindu identification is *positively* associated with the notion that, instead of fighting, upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus should work together to achieve their common interests (0.132, s.e.=0.035,  $p<0.01$ ). Consistent with hypothesis 3, a unit shift in Hindu identification is associated with a 13.2% increase in support for shared mobilization. These effects stem largely from upper-caste Hindus. These heterogeneous effects are likely because lower-caste Hindus report greater agreement with the statement at baseline than upper-caste Hindus (86.3% > 72.4%), plausibly indicating ceiling effects.

Figure 3 portrays the full chain reaction linking treatment to the index of opposition to caste integration and to agreement with the notion that upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus should work together to address their common interests. The ACME of the top model is positive (0.007\*) and reliable at the 8% level or better. The ACME of the bottom model is also positive (0.003\*) and is reliable at the 7% level or better. Together, these results suggest that demographic anxieties increase the salience of Hindu identity, exacerbating social divisions between upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus but also motivating them to work together for shared interests.

## Policy Support

Thus far, I have found that demographic threats can affect group identification and social relations between different subgroups. Next, I consider how they affect support for a battery of different policy proposals. Figure 4 reports the downstream effects of Hindu identification on 2 existing affirmative action policies designed to redress caste disparities (SC/ST Reservations, OBC Reservations), two proposed policies designed to redress caste disparities (Redistribute Village land, Guarantee Amenities), and a pro-Caste index summing support for those two policies. Then, it reports the downstream effects on two pro-Hindu policies (Implement the Citizenship Amendment Act, Stop Love Jihad) and a pro-Hindu

**FIGURE 3. Exposure to Demographic Threat Increases Social Distance between Upper-Caste and Lower-Caste Hindus but also Willingness to Work Together**

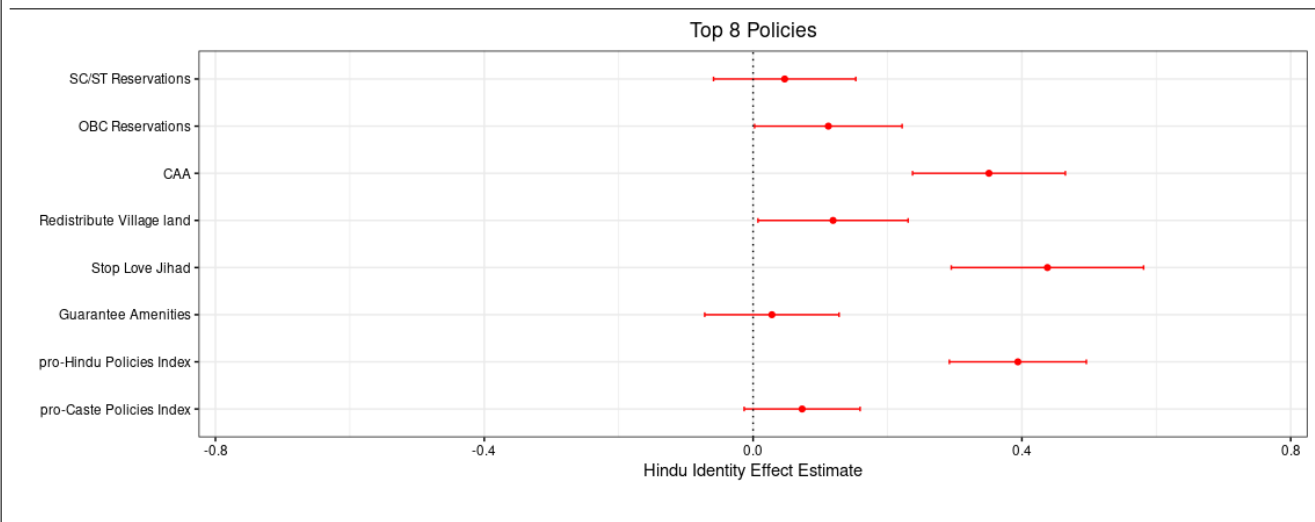


*Note:* These path diagrams depict the indirect effect of Treatment on Caste Distance and support for Castes working together. The coefficients are from the models reported in Table 1.

index summing support for those two pro-Hindu policies.

For the sake of parsimony, I focus mainly on the pro-Hindu and pro-Caste indices. In support of H4a, I find that Hindu identification has a large *positive* effect on support for pro-Hindu policies (0.394\*\*\*, s.e.=0.052,  $p < 0.01$ ). As Table A2 reports, these findings emerge among both upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus. Contrary to H4b, I find that Hindu identification also has a small *positive* effect on support for pro-Caste policies (0.073\*, s.e.=0.044,  $p = 0.093$ ) as well. These findings emerge largely

**FIGURE 4. Marginal Effects of Hindu Identification on Policy Support**



*Note:* This figure displays marginal effects of Hindu Identification on different measures on Policy Support. Coefficients are based on Table A2 in the appendix. 95% confidence intervals are shown. Outcome variables range from 0-1.

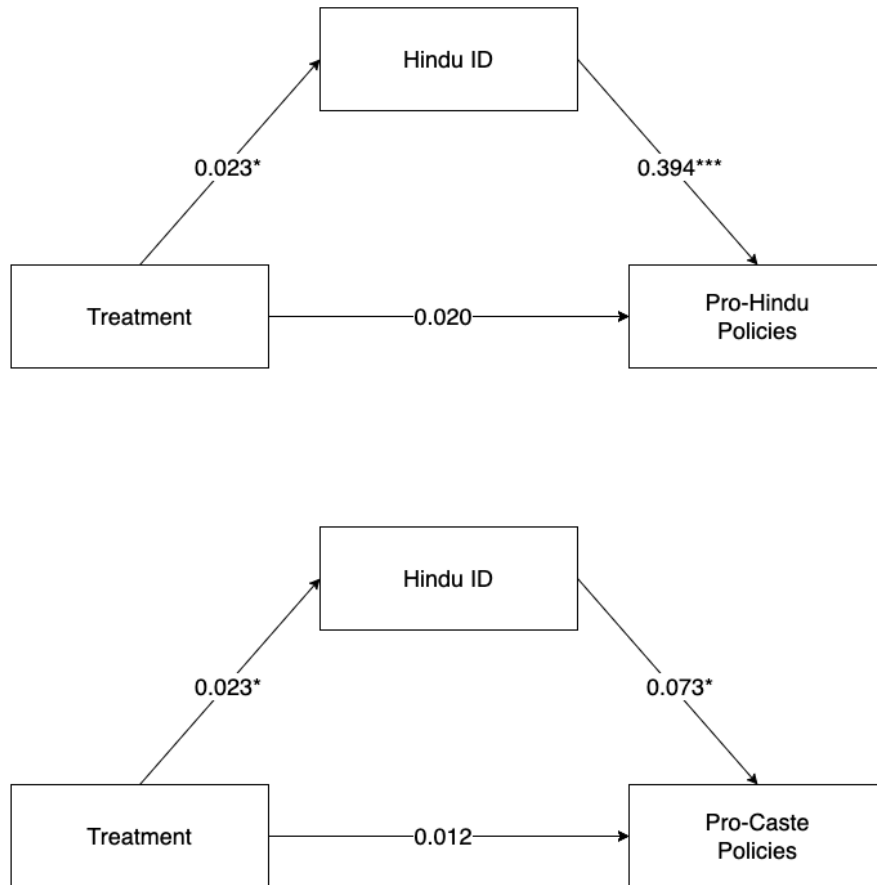
from upper-caste Hindus, possibly because lower-caste Hindus already support these policies to a large degree.

Figure 5 portrays mediation models depicting the results for both indices. The ACME of the top model (pro-Hindu policies) is positive (0.009\*) and is reliable at the 6% level or better. The ACME of the bottom model (pro-Caste policies) is positive (0.002) but is not reliable at any conventional level of significance. These results suggest that priming Hindus with the threat of demographic change might increase support for both pro-Caste and pro-Hindu policies but clearly increases support for pro-Hindu policies *more consistently* and *by a larger amount* than for pro-Caste policies. These results are consistent not only for the policy indices but also individual policies. Not a single pro-Caste policy has a larger coefficient than any of the pro-Hindu policies.

## Policy Preferences

Considering that Hindu identification has a positive association with support for both pro-Caste policies and pro-Hindu policies, I now test explicitly how priming demographic anxieties affects respondents' choices between them. I use three different outcomes that directly capture these choices. The first asks respondents what policy they believe is the most important to achieve and measures whether respon-

**FIGURE 5. Exposure to Demographic Threat Increases Support for pro-Hindu Policies More Than Support for pro-Caste Policies**

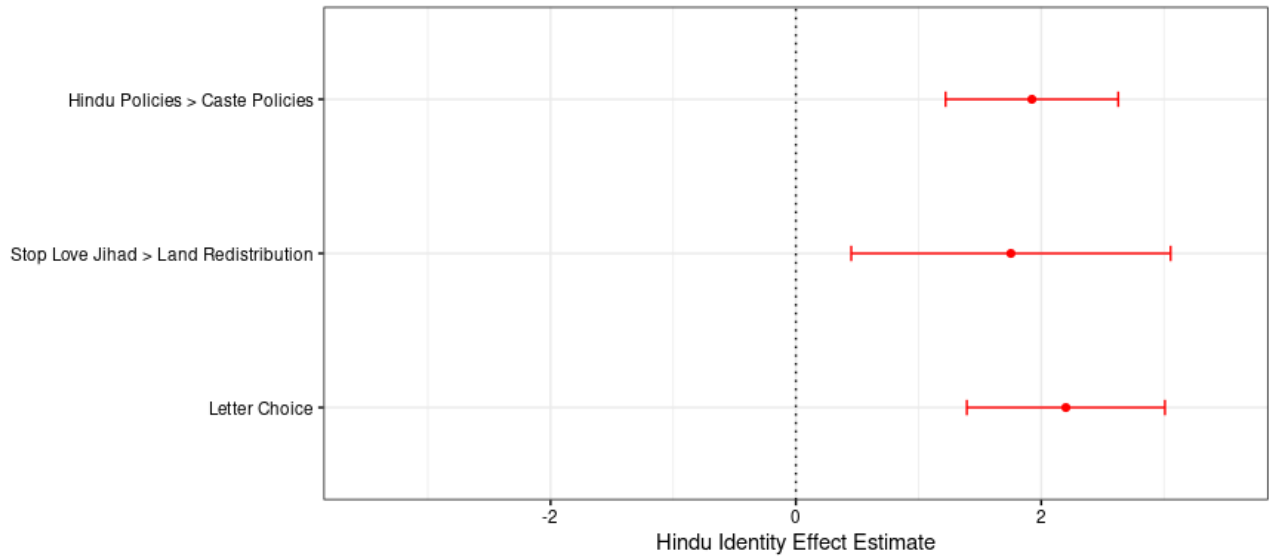


*Note:* These path diagrams depicts the indirect effect of Treatment on support for pro-Hindu Policies and pro-Caste Policies, respectively. The coefficients are from the models reported in the appendix.

dents choose a pro-Hindu policy or a pro-Caste policy. The second measures how respondents chose between the most-favored pro-Hindu policy (Stop Love Jihad) and the most-favored pro-Caste policy (Redistribute Village land). The third measures how respondents chose between two letters addressed to parliament, one pro-Hindu and the other pro-Caste.

Figure 6 reports the downstream effects of Hindu identification on these three measures of policy preferences. These regressions are estimated as logistic regressions, with outcome variables taking values of 1 when respondents choose the pro-Hindu option(s) and 0 otherwise. The estimates provided in

**FIGURE 6. Marginal Effects of Hindu Identification on Policy Preferences**



*Note:* This figure displays marginal effects of Hindu Identification on different measures on Policy Support. Coefficients are based on Table A3 in the appendix. 95% confidence intervals are shown. Outcome variables range from 0-1.

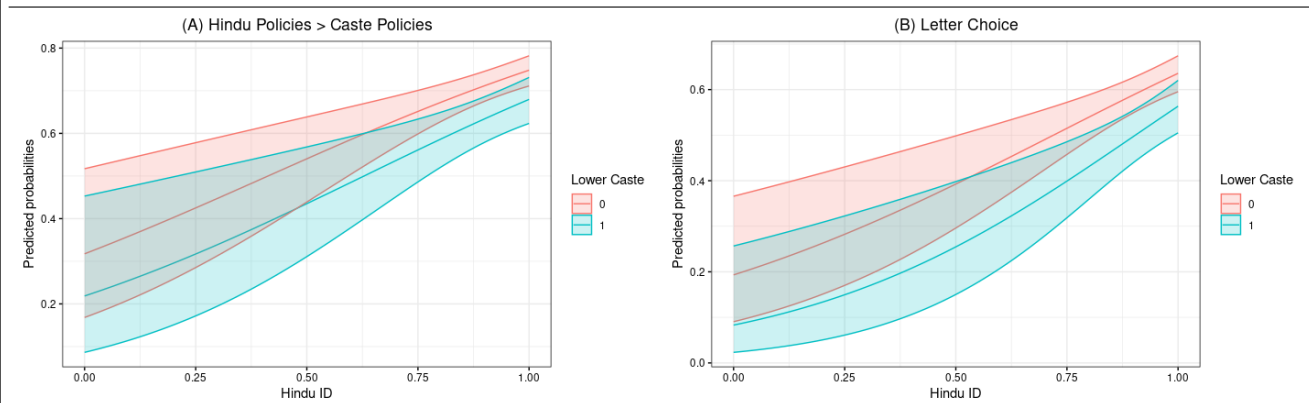
Figure 6 are, therefore, the natural logarithm(s) of the odds of prioritizing a pro-Hindu policy over a pro-Caste policy. In support of H4c, I find that Hindu identification increases the odds of prioritizing pro-Hindu policies over pro-caste policies by almost 7 times ( $e^{1.924} = 6.85$ ). Similarly, I find that Hindu identification increases the odds of prioritizing stopping Love Jihad over redistributing village land by almost 6 times ( $e^{1.924} = 5.77$ ). Finally, I find that Hindu identification increases the odds of choosing the pro-Hindu letter over the pro-Caste letter by 9 times ( $e^{2.201} = 9.03$ ). Tests of heterogeneous effects are insignificant for all three logistic regressions. Upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus increase their support for pro-Hindu policies over pro-Caste policies to a similar degree.

In figure 7, I convert these odds ratios into predicted probabilities. At low levels of Hindu identification, the probability of prioritizing Hindu policies over Caste policies is 27.89%. At high levels of Hindu identification, the probability increases to 72.59%. Similarly, moving from low levels of Hindu identification to higher levels results in an increase in the probability of picking the pro-Hindu letter over the pro-Caste letter by 46.34%. In both panels, the curves for upper-caste (red) and lower-caste (blue) respondents are largely superimposed on each other, indicating largely homogeneous effects. However,

visually, the effects of Hindu identification on policy preferences seem slightly larger for the former than the latter.

Since the actual effect of treatment on Hindu identification is small (0.023, s.e.=0.012,  $p=0.059$ ), the resultant ACMEs for the three measures of policy preferences are relatively small as well (0.009\*) for Hindu Policies preferred, which is reliable at the 7% level or better, (0.005) for Hindu policy preferred (Stopping Love Jihad over Redistributing Village land), which is not reliable at any conventional level of significance<sup>8</sup>, and (0.012\*) for Letter Choice, which is reliable at the 6% level or better. Demographic threats seem to have a small but consistent effect, inducing Hindus of all castes to prioritize pro-Hindu policies over pro-Caste policies.

**FIGURE 7. Marginal Effects of Hindu Identification on Policy Preferences with 95% Confidence Intervals**



*Note:* These graphs represent the predicted probabilities associated with prioritizing Hindu Policies over Caste Policies (Panel A) and prioritizing sending the Pro-Hindu letter over the Pro-Caste Letter (Panel B) with 95% confidence intervals drawn around the main curve using robust standard errors. Results are bifurcated based on caste: upper-caste is red, and lower-caste is blue.

## Discussion and Conclusion

Corroborating prior results from Western contexts (see, for example, Perez et al. 2023; Kim 2023 Outten, Schmitt, Miller, and Garcia 2012), I find that priming respondents to think about demographic change catalyzes Hindu identity. Although my effect sizes are slightly smaller than results from comparable

<sup>8</sup>This is possibly due to the very small sample size for this measure ( $N = 329$ ). As Figure 4 indicates, confidence intervals for this measure are larger than for any other measure.



studies elsewhere (2.3% vs 3.2% in Perez et al., 2023), this is reasonably attributable to the fact that Hindu identification at baseline is far higher in my sample than, for example, White identification in prior work (91.7% vs 50.6% in Perez et al., 2023).

I find that Hindu identity unexpectedly leads both upper and lower-caste Hindus to express more attachment to their subgroup caste affiliations as well. Hindu identification, rather than ameliorating intragroup tensions, exacerbates social distance within the community, reducing support for cohabitation, communal dining, and intermarriage. Needless to say, these findings run contrary to much existing research based on the common ingroup identity model (see, for example, Choi, Poertner, and Sambanis 2023, although see Itzigsohn and Dore-Cabral 2000, for contradictory findings suggesting that panethnic identification does not erase tensions between different Latino groups).

My results problematize existing work linking demographic threats to policy support. Echoing findings from the United States (see Perez, Vicuna and Ramos 2023; Jardina 2019), I do find that priming respondents with population shifts induces support for “policies that protect the ingroup.” However, in contrast with a vast literature linking increasing immigration to the retrenchment of the welfare state (see: Alesina, Miano, and Stantcheva 2023; Achard and Suetens 2023), I find that opposition to redistributive policies is inelastic to demographic threat, shaped primarily by prior caste affiliations.

Although priming population shifts in this study does not undermine support for pro-Caste policies absolutely, it does undermine support for these policies *relatively*. Cohering with observational evidence from Europe and the West more broadly, (Sladkova, Kim, and Cook 2021; Gest 2016), my results show that thinking about increasing diversity motivates Hindus of all caste groups to prioritize collective pro-Hindu policies over redistributive policies like affirmative action and welfare.

## **Interpreting Unanticipated Findings**

Why does identification with the Hindu superordinate group not undermine internal caste hierarchies? For common identities to eliminate intragroup boundaries, superordinate identification must motivate individuals to shift their attention away from the attributes that define conflicting subgroup memberships in favor of the unifying superordinate identity instead (Sambanis and Lee 2023; Gaertner and Dovidio,

2000). My results suggest that Hindu identification, rather than reducing subgroup attachments, increases the salience of caste identities. The process of recategorization that the common ingroup identity model depends on simply does not occur.

This gives rise to perhaps a more fundamental question: Why does Hindu identification not undermine caste identification? One reason might be that, unlike Abrahamic faiths, Hinduism lacks common spiritual beliefs, sacred texts, or religious figures. While the Brahmins or Rajputs of any North Indian village typically follow the Vedas and believe in reincarnation, the Chamars, who live on the outskirts of the same villages, largely do not (Cohn 1958). Similarly, although most Hindus worship Lord Rama, the Gonds of Maharashtra, among other groups, worship his enemy, Lord Ravana (Koreti 2015). Even when different castes observe the same religious holidays, they often worship on different days or in different ways (Prajwal 2018). The symbols of Hindu identity — the rituals, beliefs, and customs one holds attachments to — are strongly determined by what caste one belongs to. I speculate that Hindu identity and caste identities might be so tightly interwoven that identifying with one necessarily means identifying with the other.

Alternatively, part of the answer might emanate from aspects of Hinduism as a “map of meaning” (Peterson 2002) that shapes how individuals perceive and make sense of the world around them. The caste hierarchies that induce opposition to cohabitation, interdining, and marital relations are not external but intrinsic to Hinduism itself. Pollution and purity narratives underlie much of Hindu scripture, from the Mahabharata and the Bhagavad Gita to the Manusmriti (Stevenson 1954). Chhibber and Verma (2018), for example, document that Hindu texts posit that the maintenance of “dharma” or universal justice depends on the policing of caste boundaries. Similarly, Mehta (1992) notes that Valmiki, the author of the Ramayana<sup>9</sup>, argued that even if some movement was possible between the castes, there must always be clear distinctions between them. These paradigms shape the Hindu worldview to this day, such that existing surveys of Hindu religiosity typically ask respondents to what degree they adhere to caste norms (see Verghese 2023).

Together, these results suggest that in contexts where superordinate identities are deeply intertwined with subordinate identities or where the hierarchical frameworks delineating some subgroups

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<sup>9</sup>One of the central religious texts in Hinduism.

above others are inexorably enmeshed within the content of the superordinate identity itself, priming shared identities might not necessarily undermine intragroup distinctions and may even serve to exacerbate them further. Further research is required on (i) the degree to which superordinate and subordinate identities can be distinguished, (ii) the role played by the content of these identities in shaping intragroup relations, and (iii) the consequential results of shared identification.

## **Implications and Final Thoughts**

Prior studies show that external threats induce support for ingroup-oriented policies (Perez et al., 2023; Jardina 2019; Craig and Richeson 2014a; Outten, Schmitt, Miller, and Garcia 2012). This study builds upon this literature, showing that external threats primarily induce support for policies that protect the “collective” ingroup. Once primed with external threats, group members tend to prefer policies that benefit the group as a whole over “divisive” policies that either solely benefit their own subgroup or benefit one subgroup at the expense of others.

These findings suggest that superordinate identities can demobilize disadvantaged (sub)groups. In contexts with deep internal inequalities, identification with the common ingroup can motivate group members to prioritize improving the standing of the group as a whole over improving the standing of one’s subgroup within the group. By leading individuals to adopt such a “false consciousness” (Pines 1993; Engels 1893), superordinate identities can undermine support for redistribution and other efforts to redress intragroup inequalities (Jaśko and Kossowska 2013).

My evidence suggests that groups can consolidate politically even as the social hierarchies that position some group members above others intensify. It does not matter that upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus report less willingness to live near each other, dine with one another, or marry each other; so long as Muslims represent a common bugaboo, Hindus will coalesce to maintain their common position, even when the policies they coalesce around reflect culture war symbolic concerns like banning interfaith marriages or throwing out illegal immigrants, and they have the option to choose redistributive policies that could actually improve disadvantaged Hindu’s material standings instead.

Importantly, my findings suggest that these effects emanate largely through Hindu identification.

Table A4 reports both the Average Causal Mediation Effect (ACME), which measures the effects of treatment on outcomes mediated through Hindu identification, and the Average Direct Effect (ADE), which measures all other pathways by which exposure to treatment affects my outcome variables. Besides support for marriage segregation and redistributing village land, no other outcome reports a significant ADE. Although my mediation analyses do not allow me to make causal claims linking superordinate identification to the battery of outcomes, they do allow me to say that the effects of priming population shifts on social distance, policy support, and policy preferences occur primarily through increased Hindu identification.

Strikingly, treated respondents in my survey, whether upper or lower-caste, come to prioritize policies that hurt Muslims (throwing out illegal immigrants and banning interfaith marriages) over policies that benefit disadvantaged Hindus. This has important social justice implications, not only for intergroup relations between Hindus and Muslims but also for intragroup relations between upper-caste and lower-caste Hindus as well. In showing that superordinate identities demobilize demands for redistribution, my results suggest that Hindu identification has actively deleterious consequences for Hindus themselves, undermining demands for social changes that could actively improve real outcomes for the largest subgroup within the Hindu community.

That superordinate identities specifically play a role in reshaping subgroup distance and undermining support for intragroup redistribution is incredibly consequential for scholars and activists seeking to design interventions to reduce prejudice and promote group consolidation (see, for example, Cocco, Vezzali, Kola-Daisi, Çakal 2023; Charnysh, Lucas, & Singh 2014; Dovidio, Gartner, and Kafati 2000). Based on my findings, I recommend that future experiments include questions capturing whether their interventions (i) alter respondents' attitudes towards intragroup hierarchies and their willingness to redress them, and (ii) redirect social tensions and political mobilization against the common outgroup instead.

Finally, I do not believe that these results are unique to the Hindu or Indian context. The formation of Pakistan, for example, depended on the All-India Muslim League's careful deprioritization of Shia concerns in favor of collective Muslim mobilization (Rieck 2015). Turning to Israel, where social distinctions between Ashkenazi and Mizrahi Jews remain highly salient (Elia-Shalev 2022), Mizrahis constitute the main support base of the Jewish supremacist Likud party, despite its capitalist stances

that undermine their economic interests (Heller 2015). Understanding politics in diverse contexts with panethnic identities and movements, particularly when different subsections of these groups have competing interests, will make tracing out the mobilizing and demobilizing roles of common identities increasingly important.

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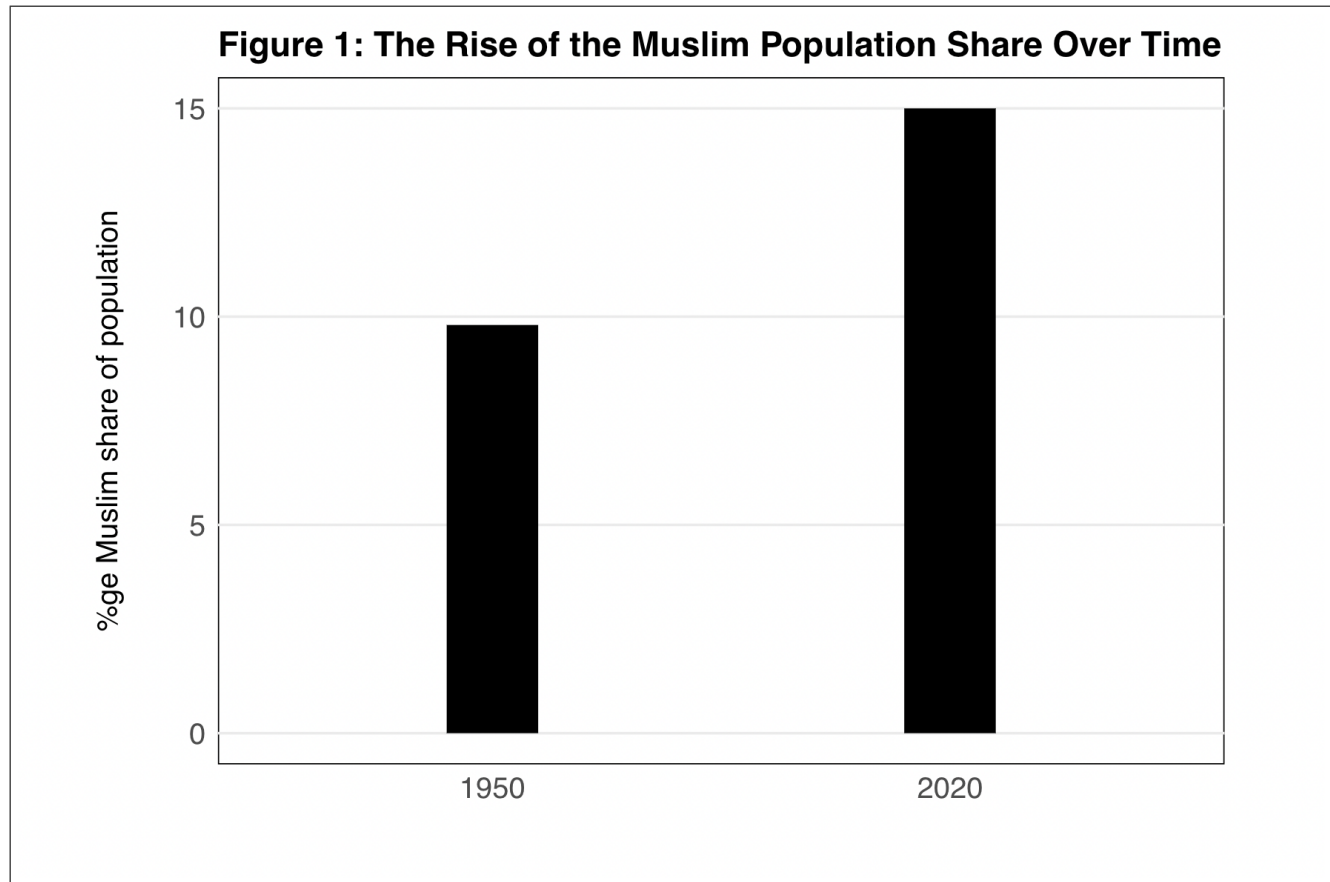
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## Appendix

### Treatment Passage

#### India's Changing Demographics is Gradually Shifting the Centre of Power in Politics, the Economy, and Society

Over the last 70 years the Muslim share of the population has grown tremendously. While they formed 9.8% of the population post-independence, today, Muslims make up nearly 15% of the population. In some parts of the country like Old Hyderabad, Malappuram, and Kashmir, they form a demographic majority, with Hindus as a minority. This evolving demographic change is producing a slow, but noticeable shift in the center of gravity in politics, the economy, and society.



These trends are noticeable in over-time data on the Indian population. For example, figure 1 shows the change in the proportion of Muslims from 1950 to 2020. According to the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5), in 2019-21, the average Hindu family had less than 2 children, while the average Muslim family had more than 2 children. This high fertility has allowed the Muslim population

to increase from between 25-30% every decade since 1960. These demographic changes have boosted political power for Indian Muslims through the election of leaders who are from their own communities. This means a more unified and robust voice for Muslims in the halls of political power.

## Tables

**TABLE 1. Hindu Identification Mediates the Relationship between Demographic Change and Policy Preferences**

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                | <i>Effect on Mediator</i> | <i>Effect on Outcomes</i> |                        |                     |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------|------------------------|---------------------|
|                                                                                                                                                                                                                | Hindu ID                  | Hindu Policies Preferred  | Hindu Policy Preferred | Letter Choice       |
| <b>Panel A: Full Sample (<math>N = 994</math>)</b>                                                                                                                                                             |                           |                           |                        |                     |
| Treatment                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 0.023*<br>(0.012)         |                           |                        |                     |
| Hindu ID                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                           | 1.924***<br>(0.359)       | 1.753***<br>(0.664)    | 2.201***<br>(0.412) |
| <b>Panel B: Upper-Caste Hindus (<math>N = 665</math>)</b>                                                                                                                                                      |                           |                           |                        |                     |
| Treatment                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 0.023*<br>(0.012)         |                           |                        |                     |
| Hindu ID                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                           | 1.854***<br>(0.467)       | 1.923*<br>(0.969)      | 1.986***<br>(0.513) |
| <b>Panel C: Lower-Caste Hindus (<math>N = 329</math>)</b>                                                                                                                                                      |                           |                           |                        |                     |
| Treatment                                                                                                                                                                                                      | 0.027*<br>(0.023)         |                           |                        |                     |
| Hindu ID                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                           | 2.026***<br>(0.565)       | 1.387<br>(0.899)       | 2.657***<br>(0.724) |
| <i>Note:</i> Entries are OLS coefficients with robust standard errors in parentheses. All variables range from 0 to 1. * $p < .10$ or better, ** $p < .05$ or better, and *** $p < .01$ or better, two-tailed. |                           |                           |                        |                     |

| TABLE 2. Hindu Identification Mediates the Relationship between Demographic Change and Social Distance                                                                                         |                   |                         |                     |                      |                     |                      |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|-------------------------|---------------------|----------------------|---------------------|----------------------|
| Effect on Mediator                                                                                                                                                                             |                   | Effect on Outcomes      |                     |                      |                     |                      |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                | Hindu ID          | Residential Segregation | Food Segregation    | Marriage Segregation | Caste Distance      | Castes Work Together |
| <b>Panel A: Full Sample (<math>N = 994</math>)</b>                                                                                                                                             |                   |                         |                     |                      |                     |                      |
| Treatment                                                                                                                                                                                      | 0.023*<br>(0.012) |                         |                     |                      |                     |                      |
| Hindu ID                                                                                                                                                                                       |                   | 0.336***<br>(0.069)     | 0.333***<br>(0.067) | 0.293***<br>(0.069)  | 0.321***<br>(0.059) | -0.015<br>(0.029)    |
| <b>Panel B: Upper-Caste Hindus (<math>N = 665</math>)</b>                                                                                                                                      |                   |                         |                     |                      |                     |                      |
| Treatment                                                                                                                                                                                      | 0.021<br>(0.014)  |                         |                     |                      |                     |                      |
| Hindu ID                                                                                                                                                                                       |                   | 0.427***<br>(0.079)     | 0.385***<br>(0.071) | 0.354***<br>(0.086)  | 0.389***<br>(0.062) | 0.022<br>(0.030)     |
| <b>Panel C: Lower-Caste Hindus (<math>N = 329</math>)</b>                                                                                                                                      |                   |                         |                     |                      |                     |                      |
| Treatment                                                                                                                                                                                      | 0.027<br>(0.023)  |                         |                     |                      |                     |                      |
| Hindu ID                                                                                                                                                                                       |                   | 0.208*<br>(0.117)       | 0.262**<br>(0.124)  | 0.197*<br>(0.115)    | 0.222**<br>(0.109)  | -0.076<br>(0.056)    |
| Note: Entries are OLS coefficients with robust standard errors in parentheses. All variables range from 0 to 1. *p < .10 or better, **p < .05 or better, and ***p < .01 or better, two-tailed. |                   |                         |                     |                      |                     |                      |

| TABLE 3. Hindu Identification Mediates the Relationship between Demographic Change and Policy Support                                                                                          |  |                   |                    |                    |                     |                           |                     |                    |                     |                     |                     |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|-------------------|--------------------|--------------------|---------------------|---------------------------|---------------------|--------------------|---------------------|---------------------|---------------------|
| Effect on Mediator                                                                                                                                                                             |  |                   | Effect on Outcomes |                    |                     |                           |                     |                    |                     |                     |                     |
|                                                                                                                                                                                                |  | Hindu ID          | SC/ST Reservations | OBC Reservations   | EWS Reservations    | Redistribute Village Land | Guarantee Amenities | Pro-Caste Index    | CAA                 | Stop Love Jihad     | Pro-Hindu Index     |
| Panel A: Full Sample (N = 994)                                                                                                                                                                 |  |                   |                    |                    |                     |                           |                     |                    |                     |                     |                     |
| Treatment                                                                                                                                                                                      |  | 0.023*<br>(0.012) |                    |                    |                     |                           |                     |                    |                     |                     |                     |
| Hindu ID                                                                                                                                                                                       |  |                   | 0.047<br>(0.054)   | 0.112**<br>(0.056) | 0.122***<br>(0.045) | 0.119**<br>(0.057)        | 0.028<br>(0.051)    | 0.073*<br>(0.044)  | 0.351***<br>(0.058) | 0.438***<br>(0.073) | 0.394***<br>(0.052) |
| Panel B: Upper-Caste Hindus (N = 665)                                                                                                                                                          |  |                   |                    |                    |                     |                           |                     |                    |                     |                     |                     |
| Treatment                                                                                                                                                                                      |  | 0.021<br>(0.014)  |                    |                    |                     |                           |                     |                    |                     |                     |                     |
| Hindu ID                                                                                                                                                                                       |  |                   | 0.102<br>(0.075)   | 0.154**<br>(0.076) | 0.145**<br>(0.066)  | 0.183**<br>(0.079)        | 0.100<br>(0.074)    | 0.141**<br>(0.059) | 0.431***<br>(0.079) | 0.437***<br>(0.093) | 0.434***<br>(0.067) |
| Panel C: Lower-Caste Hindus (N = 329)                                                                                                                                                          |  |                   |                    |                    |                     |                           |                     |                    |                     |                     |                     |
| Treatment                                                                                                                                                                                      |  | 0.027<br>(0.023)  |                    |                    |                     |                           |                     |                    |                     |                     |                     |
| Hindu ID                                                                                                                                                                                       |  |                   | −0.009<br>(0.060)  | 0.080<br>(0.060)   | 0.090*<br>(0.053)   | 0.033<br>(0.073)          | −0.072<br>(0.049)   | −0.020<br>(0.054)  | 0.227***<br>(0.075) | 0.434***<br>(0.117) | 0.330***<br>(0.080) |
| Note: Entries are OLS coefficients with robust standard errors in parentheses. All variables range from 0 to 1. *p < .10 or better, **p < .05 or better, and ***p < .01 or better, two-tailed. |  |                   |                    |                    |                     |                           |                     |                    |                     |                     |                     |

**TABLE 4. Average Direct Effects (ADEs) of Exposure to Treatment & Average Causal Mediation Effects (ACMEs) through Hindu Identification**

| Variable                  | ADEs                     | ACMEs                   |
|---------------------------|--------------------------|-------------------------|
| Jati Identification       | 0.009<br>[-0.02, 0.04]   | 0.016*<br>[0, 0.03]     |
| Residential Segregation   | 0.024<br>[-0.030, 0.08]  | 0.008*<br>[0, 0.02]     |
| Food Segregation          | 0.003<br>[-0.048, 0.06]  | 0.008**<br>[0, 0.02]    |
| Marriage Segregation      | 0.049**<br>[0.002, 0.10] | 0.006*<br>[0, 0.01]     |
| Caste Distance            | 0.027<br>[-0.013, 0.07]  | 0.007*<br>[0, 0.02]     |
| Castes Work Together      | 0.001<br>[-0.02, 0.02]   | 0.003*<br>[0, 0.01]     |
| SC/ST Reservation         | -0.016<br>[-0.061, 0.03] | 0.001<br>[-0.002, 0.01] |
| OBC Reservation           | 0.001<br>[-0.041, 0.05]  | 0.003<br>[0, 0.01]      |
| EWS Reservation           | -0.024<br>[-0.056, 0.01] | 0.003*<br>[0, 0.01]     |
| Redistribute Village land | 0.035*<br>[-0.006, 0.08] | 0.003*<br>[0, 0.01]     |
| Guarantee Amenities       | -0.01<br>[-0.048, 0.03]  | 0.001<br>[-0.002, 0]    |
| Pro-Caste Policies Index  | 0.012<br>[-0.023, 0.04]  | 0.002<br>[0, 0.01]      |
| CAA                       | 0.02<br>[-0.007, 0.05]   | 0.008*<br>[0, 0.02]     |
| Stop Love Jihad           | 0.022<br>[-0.015, 0.06]  | 0.01*<br>[0, 0.03]      |
| Pro-Hindu Policies Index  | 0.02<br>[-0.007, 0.05]   | 0.009*<br>[0, 0.02]     |
| Hindu Policies Preferred  | 0.024<br>[-0.032, 0.08]  | 0.009*<br>[0, 0.02]     |
| Hindu Policy Preferred    | 0.006<br>[-0.097, 0.11]  | 0.005<br>[-0.011, 0.02] |
| Letter Choice             | 0.039<br>[-0.020, 0.10]  | 0.012*<br>[0, 0.03]     |

*Note:* Estimates of Average Direct Effect and an Average Causal Mediation Effect transmitted through Hindu Identification from Treatment to outcomes. \*p < .10 or better, \*\*p < .05 or better, and \*\*\*p < .01 or better, two-tailed.